

Tejada out, Hynes iffy, others circling in Arlington County Board race

by SCOTT McCaffrey, Staff Writer
Jan 29, 2015



Walter Tejada fields queries from the press at the Arlington County Board meeting on Jan. 1, 2013. (Photo by Scott McCaffrey)

Arlington County Board Vice Chairman Walter Tejada on Jan. 28 informed Arlington County Democratic Committee leaders by letter that he did not plan to seek re-election in November.

“Serving on the County Board has allowed me the opportunity to tackle a broad range of issues that have strengthened our community,” Tejada wrote to party chair Kip Malinosky. “It has also been a real privilege and honor to seek ways to empower low-income, minority and immigrant residents in Arlington, the region, the state and across the country, and to encourage their participation in our society.”

Tejada said he planned to serve out his term, sparing Arlington voters another in a series of special elections that seemed to be the norm, rather than the exception, last year.

Tejada’s decision not to seek to hold on to the seat he has held for nearly 12 years took many by surprise, but there had been a hint buried in financial reports filed with the State Board of Elections. The Tejada Victory Fund had about \$16,000 on hand at the end of 2014, a somewhat light cash cushion for fighting what could be a crowded Democratic primary battle later this year.

The seats of Tejada and fellow Democrat Mary Hynes are on the ballot in November. Hynes has not yet publicly announced her intentions. Prospective Democratic candidates have been circling the political waters in recent months, and are likely to formally announce plans to run at next week’s monthly meeting of the Arlington County Democratic Committee.

Tejada has served on the County Board since 2003, when he was elected in a special election to succeed Charles Monroe, who died in office. He was re-elected in the 2003, 2007 and 2011 general elections.

This year, Tejada is serving as vice chairman, which under ordinary circumstances would have meant a move up to chairman in 2016. He chaired the board in 2008 and 2013.

In his letter to Malinosky, Tejada said he would not be able to attend the Feb. 4 Democratic Committee meeting, but expected to make a statement to the rank-and-file at the March meeting.

"I remain committed to all of Arlington, in particular ensuring that the least privileged are heard, protecting our safety net, fighting for affordable housing, and providing a voice for many who frequently go voiceless," he wrote. "I have enjoyed upholding these core values, and will continue to do so in the future."

Tejada was a close ally of County Board member Chris Zimmerman, who resigned last year. Recently, he became a minority of one on the most controversial issue of the day, when board colleagues Hynes and Jay Fisette abandoned the Columbia Pike streetcar project, leaving Tejada the lone board member in favor of the project.

In monologues at several County Board meetings after that decision, Tejada was extremely critical of the decision, which he said would hurt efforts to retain affordable housing along the South Arlington corridor.

Tejada also has sparred with fellow board members and county staff over the future of the Arlington government's volunteer office, which some want to outsource but Tejada has fought to retain.

Tejada lives in Dominion Hills with his wife, Robin Liten-Tejada, a county teacher and school administrator.

A native of El Salvador, Tejada emigrated to the U.S. in his teens, later becoming a U.S. citizen. He became active in Arlington civic life as an advocate for sports leagues and affordable housing. Before being elected, he served at various times on the Fiscal Affairs Advisory Commission, the Affordable Housing Task Force, Sports Commission, Neighborhood Day Organizing Committee and Bicentennial Celebration Task Force.

After Monroe died while chairing a board meeting in January 2003, Tejada won a Democratic caucus over Albert Eisenberg and Christian Dorsey to be the nominee for the subsequent special election that spring. He went on to defeat Republican Mike Clancy, 11,802 votes to 9,788, in the special election to fill out the remaining months of Monroe's term.

Tejada then ran in three general elections (the top two vote-getters winning office):

2003: Paul Ferguson (D), 20,109 votes; Tejada, 18,839; Rich Kelsey (R), 11,769; Sarah Summerville (R), 9,947.

2007: Tejada, 18,766 votes; Hynes, 18,203; Michael McMenamin (R), 11,426; Joseph Warren (R), 6,464; Joshua Ruebner (Gr.), 3,725.

2011: Hynes, 24,453; Tejada, 23,594; Audrey Clement (Gr.), 9,728.

If they wind up with more than two contenders for the two board seats, Arlington Democrats are expected to opt for a state-run primary in June to select their nominees for County Board this year.